



Ages 14 to 18

Misogyny, Sexual Harassment and Healthy Relationships

What it is, how it affects everyone, what the law says, and what you can do. For all students.

Before You Read

This guide covers sexual harassment, sexual violence, image-based abuse and controlling relationships.

This guide covers misogyny, sexual harassment, sexual violence, nude image sharing and controlling relationships. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something that has happened to you or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Rape Crisis 24/7 Support Line** (ages 16 and over): 0808 500 2222.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students, boys and girls**. It explains what misogyny and sexual harassment are, how they affect everyone, what the law says, and what you can do.

- **Most boys and young men are respectful** to girls, young women and each other.
- Girls are more likely to be the victims of sexual harassment and sexual violence, and it is more likely to be carried out by boys. **Anyone can be affected**, including boys and lesbian, gay, bisexual or gender-questioning students, who may find it harder to report.
- The aim is to challenge harmful ideas and behaviour, not to blame a whole group of people.

Key Words

Misogyny

Dislike of, contempt for, or prejudice against women and girls. It can be jokes and comments, or beliefs that women are worth less than men.

Sexual harassment

Unwanted conduct of a sexual nature, in person or online: comments, jokes, touching, images or messages that make someone feel intimidated, degraded or humiliated.

Sexual violence

Sexual assault, assault by penetration or rape. These are serious crimes.

Consent

Agreeing by choice, with the freedom and capacity to make that choice. It can be withdrawn at any time. Silence isn't consent, and someone who is asleep or pressured can't consent.

Coercive control

A pattern of controlling behaviour in a relationship: checking your phone, deciding who you see, making you scared to disagree or break up.

Image-based abuse

Taking, sharing or threatening to share intimate images without consent, including fake or AI-made "deepfake" images, and sextortion (blackmail with images).

What It Can Look Like

At School

- Sexist "jokes", comments about bodies, or "rating" people
- Unwanted touching: grabbing, pulling at clothes, lifting skirts, flicking bras
- Rumours about someone's sexual activity
- Talking over girls or dismissing their ideas
- Pressure on boys to prove themselves by how they treat girls

Online

- Pressure to send nudes, or nudes shared without consent
- Fake or AI-made nude images of real people
- Sextortion: "send money or more pictures or I'll share this"

- Group chats with sexist or degrading content
- Unwanted sexual images (cyberflashing)
- Influencer content that says women owe men attention, obedience or sex

In Relationships

- Checking your phone, or demanding your passwords or location
- Telling you who you can see, or what you can wear
- Making you feel scared to disagree or to break up
- Pressure or threats to get sex or images
- Jealousy presented as "proof of love"

"It Was Just Banter"

Banter is mutual: everyone is in on it and nobody is hurt. If someone feels intimidated, humiliated or unsafe, it isn't banter. National guidance for schools is clear that sexual harassment should never be passed off as "banter", "just having a laugh", "part of growing up" or "boys being boys".

How It Affects Everyone

Girls and Young Women

- Feeling unsafe in some places, or changing routes, clothes or behaviour
- Staying quiet in class or avoiding activities such as sport
- Anxiety, low confidence, and being told they are "overreacting"

Boys and Young Men

- Pressure to act dominant, hide feelings or join in to fit in
- Online content that feeds anger, loneliness or low self-worth
- Being targeted themselves and feeling they can't say so

How It Escalates

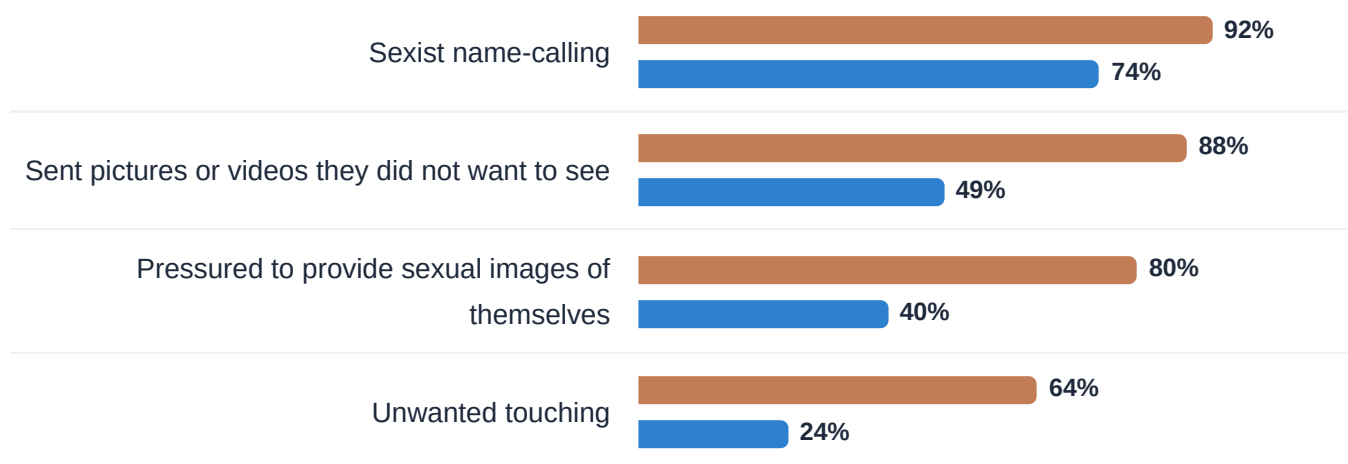
- **It starts small:** unchallenged "jokes" and comments.
- **Patterns form:** repeated comments, rating, sexist group chats.
- **Harm becomes visible:** someone starts avoiding people or places.
- **It gets serious:** images shared, harassment, assault.

The earlier someone speaks up, the easier it is to stop. You don't need to be certain before you talk to an adult.

What the Data Shows

In schools and colleges: percentage saying each happens "a lot" or "sometimes" to them or people their age.

■ Girls ■ Boys



Source: Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges*, 2021. These are perceptions of what happens among peers.

Relationships

49%

of 13 to 17 year olds who had been in a relationship in the past year experienced violent or controlling behaviour

Youth Endowment Fund, Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024 (10,000 13 to 17 year olds)

27%

of those in a relationship said they were made to feel afraid to disagree with their partner

Youth Endowment Fund, Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024 (10,000 13 to 17 year olds)

17%

of those in a relationship had explicit images or videos of themselves shared online

Youth Endowment Fund, Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024 (10,000 13 to 17 year olds)

Online

59%

of 16 to 21 year olds first saw pornography by accident, compared with 35% who looked for it

Children's Commissioner for England, survey May 2025

58%

had seen pornography showing strangulation before they turned 18. Pornography is not a guide to real, respectful relationships

Children's Commissioner for England, survey May 2025

13%

of children aged 9 to 17 had had an experience with a nude deepfake

Internet Matters, 2024

63%

of boys aged 13 to 15 had a negative view of a well-known misogynistic influencer. Most boys in the survey did not view him positively

YouGov, September 2023

Surveys ask different questions of different groups, so read each figure with its source. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges* (June 2021)
- Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024: teenage relationships*
- Children's Commissioner for England, pornography research (survey May 2025; published August 2025)
- Internet Matters, *The new face of digital abuse* (October 2024)
- YouGov Children's Omnibus (September 2023)
- Dublin City University Anti-Bullying Centre, *Recommending Toxicity* (summary report, 2024)

Consent and the Law

Consent

- Consent means agreeing by choice, freely, with the capacity to choose.
- It must be given every time, and it can be withdrawn at any point.
- Someone who is asleep, unconscious, or unable to make a free choice cannot consent. Pressure or fear means it isn't a free choice.

- Alcohol or drugs can affect someone's ability to consent. If a person is impaired, **stop**. Don't assume they can freely agree.
- The age of consent in the UK is 16.
- Respectful relationships involve kindness, care and paying attention to the other person's feelings and boundaries.

What the Law Says (England and Wales)

- **Creating, keeping or sharing indecent images of anyone under 18 can be a criminal offence**, including images someone takes of themselves and realistic AI-generated or altered images. Don't copy or forward intimate images; tell a trusted adult, who will follow safeguarding guidance.
- **Sharing, or threatening to share, intimate images of someone without consent** is a crime.
- **Sending someone unwanted sexual images** (cyberflashing) is a crime.
- **Taking a picture up someone's clothing without consent** (upskirting) is a crime.
- **Sexual assault and rape** are serious crimes.

If you've been affected, you won't be in trouble for asking for help. National guidance is clear that the law is there to protect young people, not to criminalise them, and schools respond to image-sharing as a safeguarding matter first.

Online Influence and the "Manosphere"

- **Algorithms feed you more of what you watch.** A few videos can quickly fill your feed with content that makes misogyny look normal or popular. It isn't.
- **Many influencers profit from outrage.** Ask: what are they selling? Who benefits if I believe this?
- **Some content presents women as property, or as owing men attention or sex.** Some "incel" content goes further and celebrates violence. If you see content that praises or threatens violence, tell an adult.
- **This content harms boys too:** it sells a narrow idea of what a man should be and often feeds loneliness and anger.
- **You can question the idea without attacking the person.** "Where did that come from?" often works better than an argument.

How Fast It Can Find You

2 to 17 min

In a 2024 experiment, new accounts set up as 16 and 18 year old boys interested only in gym, sport and gaming were recommended manosphere content within 2 to 17 minutes

DCU Anti-Bullying Centre, 2024

76% / 78%

of recommendations were problematic or toxic by the final round, after about two to three hours of watching (TikTok / YouTube Shorts)

DCU Anti-Bullying Centre, 2024

This was a small experiment with ten accounts, and apps have changed since. It shows how recommendation can work, not what every person sees. The point: you don't have to go looking for this content for it to find you.

Decode the Feed

Terms change quickly and people use them in different ways, from ironic jokes to real beliefs.

Glossary (11 terms)

Term	What it usually means
Manosphere	A loose network of online communities and creators focused on masculinity, dating, status and the idea that men are losing out. Not everyone in it believes the same things.
Red pill	Supposedly "waking up" to hidden truths about gender and relationships. Usually means seeing women as opponents.
Black pill	The belief that looks and genetics decide everything and nothing can change. It can feed hopelessness and resentment.
Incel	"Involuntary celibate": an online identity built around not having the relationships someone wants, often with anger towards women.
Alpha / beta / sigma	Labels used to rank boys and men. They are not real categories.
High-value man	Ranking men by money, status and physique, often paired with claims that women lose "value" with age.
Top G	A nickname for someone seen as dominant. It started as one influencer's self-branding.
Looksmaxxing	Trying to maximise attractiveness. Ranges from ordinary grooming to extreme dieting and risky DIY practices.
Mogging	Outshining someone in looks or status. Often used to rank and humiliate.

Term

What it usually means

Mewing

A tongue-posture technique claimed to reshape the jaw. Those claims are not supported by good evidence.

Manfluencer

A male influencer selling a version of masculinity, status or self-improvement.

Why It Can Be Compelling

- **Belonging:** a group, a language and an identity, especially if you feel left out.
- **Certainty:** simple rules for complicated things like relationships and success.
- **Aspiration:** money, muscles and confidence made to look easy.
- **Emotion and humour:** anger and jokes spread fast. You can reject the creator and still end up repeating the ideas.
- **Authenticity:** creators say they're "telling you what nobody else will". That is often a sales pitch.

Looksmaxxing and Body Image

- Content that rates faces and bodies can drive comparison, anxiety and low self-worth, for boys as well as girls.
- Some advice online is unsafe: extreme dieting, skipping meals, unregulated supplements or "hormone" products, and DIY procedures.
- Your worth is not your jawline, height or muscle.
- If you're worried about eating, your body or how you feel about how you look, talk to the school nurse, a school counsellor, or Childline (0800 1111).

The NOISE Check

A quick way to take a post apart before you believe it or share it.

N

Negative

Which feelings does it use?
Anger, shame, jealousy, "not good enough"

O

Oppositional

Who is set against whom?
Men vs women, "us vs them"

I

Insecurity

Which worries does it profit from? Looks, money, dating, status

S

Simplistic

What is the too-easy answer?
One fix; whole groups stereotyped

E

Earnings

Who makes money from the click, follow, course or product?

Try it: find at least one piece of evidence for each letter in this post.



@PeakMale.Protocol

Made-up account · 1.2M views

Bro. 90% of guys are invisible to women. Why? Weak jaw. Weak mindset. No money.

Women only want the top 10%. Stop being the "nice guy". Start being HIGH VALUE.

My 30-Day Alpha Protocol fixes your face, your bank account and your dating life.

Link in bio. Only 50 places left.

We made this post up; the account does not exist. The "90%" is invented too, which is part of the point.

Suggested Answers

- **N:** "invisible", "weak jaw, weak mindset": uses shame and fear of rejection
- **O:** girls framed as judges who "only want the top 10%"; "nice guys" framed as losers
- **I:** looks, money and dating: three big worries in one post
- **S:** a made-up statistic, and one programme that "fixes" your face, money and love life
- **E:** a paid programme, link in bio, "only 50 places left" to rush you, and the view count to look popular

If Something Goes Wrong Online

- Don't pay, send more images or reply to threats. Tell an adult.
- **Don't screenshot, save or forward nude images**, even as evidence. Tell an adult where they are.
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) can help get a nude image of you removed if you are under 18.
- **CEOP** (ceop.police.uk) is for reporting online sexual abuse or grooming.



RESPOND: What You Can Do

Research shows young people often tell a friend before they tell an adult. That makes you part of how people get help. RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps**, **Pause is the bridge**, and **adults lead the systems steps**.

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice the signs. Trust your instincts.

- Changes in a friend: withdrawn, anxious, avoiding people or places, glued to their phone
- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (who, and who has power?), **Places** (where?), **Platforms** (online?), **Patterns** (one-off or repeated?)
- You don't need certainty to act

E

Engage

Make contact. Listen.

- **Listen without asking for details.** Check whether your friend is safe, thank them for telling you, and offer to go with them to a trusted adult. The adults will ask any questions that are needed
- Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking this seriously. It's not your fault."
- **If you witness it, and it is safe to do so,** use the 4Ds: **Direct** ("That's not OK"), **Distract** (interrupt, change the subject, get your friend out), **Delegate** (get a trusted adult), **Delay** (check in afterwards)
- **If it isn't safe to step in, don't.** Get help instead. Inaction isn't neutral, but your safety matters

S

Support

Be present.

- First: "Are you safe right now?"
- Find somewhere quieter; fewer people, less pressure
- Listen without judging or rushing to fix it. Your calm is contagious

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Slow down before you act.

- Breathe, lower your shoulders, check how you are feeling
- Three questions: **Risk** (is anyone in danger?), **Rights** (what does my friend need?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- Don't investigate, confront the person responsible, or promise to keep it secret

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- Tell your friend what support is available, and offer to go with them
- Model the alternative: respect, consent, speaking up
- If you're unsure what to say, tell an adult first



Notify

Pass it on to a trusted adult.

- If someone tells you about **sexual harassment, abuse, sexual images, threats or controlling behaviour**, tell a trusted adult promptly, **even if they ask you not to**. If possible, tell your friend what you are going to do
- This isn't betraying them. It's how they get protected
- **Keep being their friend.** Telling an adult doesn't end your part. Friends are often the first people someone tells, and can be their safety net: check in, sit with them, include them



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. You don't need to
- Tell them clearly what you saw, what was said, and what you did

If It's Happening to You

It's Not Your Fault

- Nothing you wore, said, sent or did makes it your fault.
- You can tell any adult you trust, at any time, even if it happened a while ago or happened online or outside school.
- If the first person you tell doesn't help, tell someone else.

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.
- You'll be listened to and taken seriously.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team to keep you safe. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in what happens next and what support you get.
- In serious cases the school may need to involve parents, social care or the police. You'll be told, and supported throughout.

When It's About More Than One Thing

- Misogyny often comes mixed with racism, religious hatred, disablism or homophobia: for example, racist and sexual comments together, or harassment of girls who wear religious dress.
- Students who are lesbian, gay, bisexual, trans or questioning their gender, or who other people think are, can be targeted too. So can boys who don't fit the "alpha" mould.
- It is never your fault, and it is never "just banter". **Tell an adult about every part of it**, so it can be dealt with properly.

- Everyone has the same right to be safe and treated with respect and dignity, whatever their race, religion, disability, sexuality or gender.

Need Help With This Guide?

- If reading this guide is hard, or English isn't your first language, ask an adult you trust to go through it with you.



Boys and Girls: What We Can All Do

Boys and Young Men

- Call out sexist comments among friends, if it's safe to do so. Silence can sound like agreement
- If a mate is checking up on, or controlling, their partner, don't join in or egg them on. Controlling behaviour is often encouraged by friends; you can be the one who doesn't
- Don't forward, rate or comment on images of anyone
- Question online content that tells you what a "real man" is
- Talk about pressure, anger or loneliness; it's a strength, not a weakness
- If you're targeted or harmed, you can tell someone too

Girls and Young Women

- You have the right to feel safe, to be heard and to say no
- You don't have to laugh it off. Speaking up is not overreacting
- Back each other up and help friends tell an adult
- Misogyny isn't only from boys: challenge put-downs between girls too

Everyone

- Consent every time. "No" is a full answer
- Never share other people's images, secrets or rumours
- Be an upstander: act if it's safe; if not, tell an adult afterwards

- Challenge the idea, not the person

If You're Worried About Your Own Behaviour

If you're worried about something you've said, shared or done, or about thoughts you're having, asking for help is the right thing to do. People can and do change.

- Talk to an adult you trust at school.
- **Shore** (shorespace.org.uk), run by the Lucy Faithfull Foundation, gives anonymous advice to teenagers worried about their own or someone else's sexual thoughts or behaviour.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It was just banter"	If someone feels intimidated, humiliated or unsafe, it needs to be taken seriously. Intention doesn't decide whether it's harassment; the effect matters too.
"If they didn't say no, it's consent"	Consent is an active, free choice. Silence or pressure isn't consent, and if someone is drunk or high, stop: don't assume they can freely agree.
"Sharing a nude someone sent you isn't a big deal"	Sharing sexual images of under-18s can be a crime and can seriously harm the person in them.
"Boys can't be victims"	Boys and young men can be harassed, pressured or abused, and deserve support.
"Jealousy shows they care"	Controlling behaviour is a warning sign, not proof of love.

"Everyone agrees with those influencers"

In one national survey, most boys had a negative view of a well-known misogynistic influencer. Algorithms can make this content look more popular than it is.

"Telling an adult makes it worse"

Adults can act to keep people safe. You'll be kept informed and supported.



If You Board

Living Together

- Your boarding house is your home at school. Sexist comments, rating lists, image sharing and group-chat pile-ons are not OK there either.
- If something happens in your house, even at night, tell a house parent or the member of staff on duty. **Know how to reach staff at night.** If you don't, ask.
- Know your school's rules on relationships between boarders. Consent applies everywhere, including in the house.
- No initiation, dares or pressure to "fit in". If older students are pressuring younger ones, tell a member of staff.
- Mobile data can get round the school's filters, but the rules and the law still apply. If you see something harmful at night, tell staff: straight away if someone might be in danger.
- If someone has been harmed by a person in the same house, staff will make changes so they can feel safe. Those changes should fall on the person who is alleged to have caused the harm, not on the person harmed.
- You can talk to your family in private, at a time that works across time zones.

People You Can Talk To

- **You can always contact your house parents, the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) or a member of the boarding management team**, at any time, day or night.
- Any member of staff, in your house or at school
- Your school's **independent listener**: an adult outside the staff you can contact directly
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Help at Hand** (Children's Commissioner, for children living away from home): 0800 528 0731



Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- **Rape Crisis 24/7 Support Line** (16 and over): 0808 500 2222
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): nude images of you removed, if you are under 18
- **CEOP** (ceop.police.uk): report online sexual abuse or grooming
- **Shore** (shorespace.org.uk): anonymous advice about sexual behaviour for teenagers
- **The Mix** (themix.org.uk): online support for under-25s
- **Emergency:** call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Misogyny, Sexual Harassment and Healthy Relationships: Student Guide 101 - 14 to 18

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